ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Word, Excel and PowerPoint: Produce Assignments That Look Professional

The practical software skills behind clean reports, data work and presentations

DIGITAL SKILLS

Digital Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

A well-formatted report signals care; a spreadsheet that recalculates saves hours; a clear slide deck earns attention. This pack covers the specific features students actually need: styles, table of contents, page numbering, formulas, charts and presentation structure.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Format a long assignment using styles, headings and automatic page numbering.
- Insert a table of contents, figures and captions correctly.
- Use core Excel formulas, absolute references and simple charts.
- Design and deliver a short academic presentation.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Word: format once, not by hand

Manual formatting breaks the moment you edit. Use styles.

- Apply Heading 1, 2 and 3 styles to structure the document.
- Insert an automatic table of contents from the References tab.
- Add page numbers with a different first page where required.
- Use captions for figures and tables, then cross-reference them.
- Set consistent line spacing, margins and justified body text.
- Use track changes for group work and accept changes deliberately.

Excel: formulas that survive editing

The point of a spreadsheet is recalculation.

- Start every formula with equals and use cell references, not typed numbers.
- Relative references shift; dollar signs lock a row or column as absolute.
- Core functions: SUM, AVERAGE, COUNT, IF, VLOOKUP or XLOOKUP.
- Sort and filter before analysing; keep raw data on a separate sheet.
- Create charts from a clean table and label axes with units.
- Check totals independently rather than trusting the output.

> **The absolute reference habit**
> When copying a formula down a column, lock any cell it must keep referring to with dollar signs. This single habit prevents most spreadsheet errors.

PowerPoint: slides support you

Slides are visual aids, not a script.

- One idea per slide, stated in the title as a sentence.
- Use a readable font size and high contrast.
- Prefer a simple chart or diagram over a wall of text.
- Keep to a consistent template, colour and alignment.
- Rehearse timing and transitions; do not read the slides.
- Prepare for questions with two backup slides of evidence.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why use Word styles instead of manual formatting?

Answer: Styles apply consistent formatting and allow automatic tables of contents, navigation and easier edits.

2. What does a dollar sign do in an Excel reference?

Answer: It locks the column or row so the reference does not change when the formula is copied.

3. Write a formula to average cells B2 to B10.

Answer: =AVERAGE(B2:B10)

4. How many ideas should a slide carry?

Answer: One. Additional ideas belong on separate slides.

5. How do you verify an Excel total independently?

Answer: Recalculate using a different method, such as manual addition or a separate formula, and compare the results.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Format a two-page document using heading styles.
- [ ] Insert an automatic table of contents and page numbers.
- [ ] Add a captioned table and cross-reference it in the text.
- [ ] Build a 20-row spreadsheet with at least three formulas.
- [ ] Create one chart with labelled axes and units.
- [ ] Design a five-slide presentation on a course topic.
- [ ] Present it to a friend and take feedback on clarity.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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